



FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS — APPOINTMENTS AND CHANNELLING

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BOOKING AN APPOINTMENT

How do I book an appointment?

Appointments may be booked by calling the appointment hotline at 0112-456-789 (available 7:00 am to 8:00 pm daily), through the online portal at portal.serendibhospital.lk, or by walking in to the OPD Registration Desk, Ground Floor, Block A. A confirmation SMS is sent within 15 minutes of any online or telephone booking.

What is the channelling system?

Channelling is the term used in Sri Lanka for booking a specific doctor for an outpatient consultation. At Serendib General Hospital, each channelled patient is assigned a numbered queue slot. Your number appears on the screen outside the consultation room and you receive an SMS alert when three patients remain ahead of your turn, allowing you to wait in the café or garden rather than the waiting area.

Can I request a specific doctor?

Yes. When booking, you may request a specific consultant by name. Availability depends on the consultant's session schedule. If your preferred doctor is not available on your preferred date, the booking agent will offer the nearest available slot or suggest a colleague in the same specialty.

How early should I arrive for my appointment?

Patients with a booked appointment are advised to arrive at the OPD Registration Desk at least 20 minutes before their session begins to complete registration formalities. Arriving late may result in your slot being forfeited in favour of waiting patients, particularly during peak hours.

What documents should I bring to my appointment?

Patients are required to bring a valid National Identity Card or passport, their hospital registration card if they are a returning patient, any previous investigation reports relevant to the consultation (originals and copies), a referral letter from a GP or specialist if applicable, and a list of current medications.

Can I cancel or reschedule my appointment?

Yes. Cancellations and reschedules may be made by calling 0112-456-789 or through the patient portal. Patients are requested to cancel at least two hours before their appointment to allow the slot to be offered to another patient. Late cancellations within two hours attract a LKR 500 administrative fee, which is applied to the next booking.

What is the difference between a GP and a consultant?

A General Practitioner (GP) at Serendib manages common illnesses, preventive care, and initial assessments. A Consultant is a specialist doctor registered in a specific field such as cardiology, orthopaedics, or neurology, who typically sees patients following a referral. Consultation fees differ accordingly; see the OPD Services Directory (SGH-OPD-001) for current rates.

Can someone else book an appointment on my behalf?

Yes. A family member or caregiver may book an appointment on behalf of a patient by providing the patient's full name, NIC number, date of birth, and contact number. The confirmation SMS is sent to the number provided at the time of booking.

Is walk-in available for all departments?

Walk-in is accepted at all OPD departments, subject to the session being open and available capacity. Walk-in patients are attended to after all channelled patients within each session. During peak hours of 10:00 am to 12:00 pm and 4:00 pm to 6:00 pm, waiting times for walk-in patients may exceed 90 minutes. Advance channelling is strongly recommended for specialist consultations.

What happens if the doctor is unavailable on the day?

In the event that a consultant is unable to attend a scheduled session due to an emergency, patients are notified by SMS as early as possible. The registration desk will offer patients the option of seeing an available colleague in the same specialty, rescheduling at no charge, or obtaining a full refund of the consultation fee if already paid.

Can I get a same-day appointment?

Same-day appointments are available for General Medicine and Paediatrics on most days, subject to capacity. For specialist departments, same-day availability depends on the consultant's session and is not guaranteed. Patients are advised to call early in the morning to check availability.

How do I get a referral to a specialist?

Referrals may be obtained from any GP at Serendib General Hospital following an OPD consultation. Internal referrals are transmitted electronically to the receiving department; patients are contacted with an appointment date by SMS within 24 hours for urgent referrals and within three working days for routine referrals. External referrals from other practitioners are also accepted at the OPD desk.

What is a follow-up appointment and is there a reduced fee?

A follow-up appointment is a return visit to the same consultant within 30 days of the original consultation for the same condition. The fee for a follow-up is 50% of the applicable consultation fee. Patients must present their previous consultation receipt or hospital registration card to receive the reduced rate.

Are video consultations available?

Yes. Selected consultants offer video consultations through the Serendib patient portal for follow-up appointments and non-emergency reviews. Video consultation availability and fees are listed on the portal under each consultant's profile. In-person attendance is required for initial consultations, physical examinations, and any procedure that cannot be completed remotely.

C. Wickramasinghe

✓ Digitally Signed

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